

PART II,



History of
The Spanish-American War
in Brief,

HISTORY OF THE WAR,



To Establish Home Rule.

In February, 1895, both branches of the Spanish Cortes—in which Cuba has forty-three representatives—unanimously passed a bill brought forward by Senor Abaruza, a Cuban, to establish in Cuba a liberal regime which should virtually confer autonomy, or home rule. This was in response to the demands of the autonomist Cuban members of the Cortes. They described the stagnation of the cane sugar industry of Cuba, which was prostrated by Germany's vast exportations of cheap beet sugar, the ruin of sugar planters, the idleness of thousands of workmen formerly employed on the plantations and the necessity of local self-government, with closer economy of administration, in view of the diminished incomes of the people. Hard times had created discontent and political unrest, which it was expedient to conciliate by reforming the government and reducing its cost.

Preventive Insurrection.

Ten days after the enactment of the reform law an insurrection was begun in the Province of Santiago by filibusters from New York, Hayti and other

points. Their purpose, it has been stated, was to prevent the success of a reform which would content the people and render them indifferent to the idea of *Cuba Libre*. The filibusters consisted of young Cubans who had lived many years abroad, naturalized foreigners of Cuban origin and adventurers of various nationalities. Their enterprise was organized and financed by a junta, or committee, in New York, which was helped by the sympathy all Americans have for countries thought to be rightly struggling to be free. Cuba bonds, which would be valuable if the junta succeeded, were also disposed of, partly for the money disposed of, partly for the co-operation they secured.

The People.

There were some two hundred thousand agricultural laborers in Cuba, many of whom were idle on account of the low price of sugar. Some of these joined the rebels. The entire rebel force has been estimated at forty thousand, but the force actually under arms has perhaps seldom exceeded. Few professional men or men of education joined the insurgents. The cities and larger towns continued loyal and the local population organized guerrilla bands aggregating, it is said, fifty thousand men to withstand the forays of the rebels. The latter, consisting chiefly of negroes and mixed breeds, operated by destroying property. They did not propose to fight in the open, but burned crops and buildings and dynamited railroad bridges and trains.

So-Called Republic.

A republic was proclaimed and Cuebitas was made the capital, but the civil government was imaginary. The chief command and entire local government was in the hands of General Gomez. He, with Maceo and others, gradually extended the rebel operations over the whole island, destroying everything outside the towns. Stealing in small bands through the bush and traveling by night, they eluded the Spanish troops and burnt and plundered everywhere, driving the rustics into the already congested towns. To prevent the rebels from living off the rustics the Spanish forbade agriculture in exposed districts, thus also adding to the congestion of population in the towns. The wretchedness of reconcentrados, imputed to General Weyler, became the chief burden of the cry of inhumanity raised against Spanish rule.

Weyler's Plan.

By cutting the island into several isolated sections by means of trochas, and by following up the rebel bands pertinaciously in the restricted areas, General Weyler had, at length, by December, 1897, virtually freed the island from their ravages, except in the two easternmost provinces, where a desolate mountain country gave the insurgents impenetrable retreats. The nature of the jungle was such that the complete extinction of the rebel bands in Santiago was impracticable, so long as they received supplies and encouragement from abroad. Their operations

were on a small scale and unimportant, except so far as the existence of their movement—even on a small scale—afforded a basis for the growing disposition at Washington to interfere to exclude Spain from her possessions in the West Indies.

Mr. Cleveland's Attitude.

In December, 1896, Congress signified its purpose to recognize *Cuba Libre*, until Secretary Olney, instructed by Mr. Cleveland, let it be known that in the President's view recognition was an executive function exclusively and action by Congress would be ignored. Mr. Cleveland's position, as indicated by his representative at Madrid, was, that the plan of autonomy, embodied in the Abaruza law of 1895, and much broadened in the Decree of February, 1897, should be given a trial and the United States would not interfere until it was shown by experience that the new home rule scheme was a sham and failure. The democratic part, as voiced by Mr. Cleveland, included the idea of interference in case peace and order—after a fair trial of the home scheme of 1897—were still as far off as ever, but Mr. Cleveland assured the Madrid government that the home rule should have a fair trial. The purpose of depriving Spain of her sovereignty over Cuba was disclaimed.

New Policy.

With the beginning of the McKinley administration these assurances ceased. A less patient policy was favored and the idea of getting Spain to

withdraw from Cuba by friendly insistence was entertained. Congressmen who wished to recognize Cuba's independence were at once advised that such result could be attained in a better way. Recognition was staved off. Meanwhile Spain was asked to make various concessions, as respects the removal of Weyler, the reconcentrados and an armistice, etc. All were granted. The hope was entertained that with Blanco favoring conciliation, the reconcentrados provided for and peace offered the rebels a way would be found for giving Cuba a government as free as that of Canada. The retention of a nominal sovereignty was now at length all that Spain asked.

War.

It was resolved not to concede this and on April 11, 1898, President McKinley asked Congress to authorize him to intervene in Cuba with force. Congress assented on the 19th and an ultimatum was sent to Spain demanding the evacuation of Cuba. In the declaration of war it was affirmed that the war should be in the interest of humanity and not for the acquisition of territory.

Immediate Cause of War.

Hostilities were precipitated by the sinking of the battleship *Maine* in the harbor of Havana in February. The vessel sank after an explosion, the cause of which has not been ascertained. It is not known whether it was the work of a Spanish fanatic, animated by blind hatred of the United States, or of

a Cuban patriot anxious to embroil Spain and Cuba. That it was caused by any Spanish official nobody believes. Our commission of naval officers, after patient inquiry, reported that it could not trace the cause of the explosion, but thought it was from without the ship. Admiral Colomb, of the British Navy, reviewing the facts elicited by the inquiry, thinks the explosion was from within and parallels the incident with the like mysterious explosion of the British warship *Daphne*, which he investigated. The *Daphne* was exploded from within, but the cause could never be ascertained.

The explosion of the *Maine*, whatever the cause, fired popular resentment against Spain and strengthened the jungo party in Congress till it became irresistible. There was a loud demand for revenge and "*Remember the Maine*" became a popular cry.

Preparation and Operation.

Months before the declaration of war our warships were assembled in large numbers at Key West, near Havana, and on April 22nd, the day after war began, Admiral Sampson began the blockade of Cuban ports. The *Buena Ventura* was the first prize, taken by the *Nashville* on the 22nd, and many other Spanish merchantmen were captured within the next few weeks. In anticipation of hostilities Congress had voted \$50,000,000 to be spent at the President's discretion. A large army was authorized, and one hundred and twenty-five thousand volunteers were called out. Later seventy-five thousand

more were called out. What with the regulars and other troops authorized, an army of over a quarter of a million was finally provided for. Patriotism and popular enthusiasm caused many of the militia regiments, maintained for local purposes in the various States, to volunteer en masse for service in the federal army. In the South much gratification was felt at the appointment of ex-Confederates to important commands.

Dewey's Victory.

The first naval attack of importance was the attack made May 1st by Commodore Dewey in the Bay of Manila, in the Philippine Islands, on the Spanish fleet assembled there. The Spanish vessels were inferior and were all destroyed, without inflicting any loss upon the Americans. Aguinaldo, a Philippine rebel, was taken by us from Hong Kong to Cavite, a town near Manila, and provided with military supplies, for co-operation with us against the Spanish. So well did he use his new resources that the Spanish were beaten by the rebels at many points, and were finally cooped up by them in Manila. Meanwhile Dewey, being without troops, was unable to operate ashore. Manila was at his mercy, but he had to wait until General Merritt, with troops, was sent across the Pacific from San Francisco to his assistance. Aguinaldo improved the interval to press the siege of Manila and to proclaim a republic, with himself at its head. The United States had destroyed Spain's fleet, he confessed, but his Filipinos had expelled Spain's army from the provinces, captured

most of it and penned the feeble remnant in the capital. To the American assumption that the Philippines were to be American, he opposed the claim that they had won their independence and would retain it. The capture of Manila by the rebels would mean the butchery of the Spanish garrison. For this reason and for obvious political reasons Dewey discouraged an assault by the Filipinos on the city, expecting to take it himself ultimately and protect it with the American troops when they arrived. The situation became strained, and there was a prospect that the Americans would after a time find it necessary to fight their cantankerous allies.

In an engagement of minor vessels in Cuban waters on May 11, Ensign Bagley, of the Winslow, and four others were killed.

Havana and Cervera.

The apparent plan of campaign of the Washington government was to take Havana as the readiest way of securing the object of the war. Many troops and ships were assembled at Tampa and Key West, whence they could be speedily transported to some point on the Cuban coast near Havana. Various places along the coast were reconnoitred and some were bombarded. Such preparations, if genuine, were arrested, and the whole plan of campaign was changed on May 13th by the announcement that Admiral Cervera's fleet of four formidable warships and two torpedo-boat destroyers had arrived off Martinique, in the West Indies. It

was later seen off Curacoa, near Venezuela. On May 19th the Spanish fleet entered the harbor of Santiago, on the southern coast of Cuba. Its presence there was definitely ascertained by Commodore Schley. As it was impossible to transport troops for the capture of Havana while Cervera's fleet was in striking distance, it became the chief object of the army and navy to capture or destroy the fleet.

Hobson's Feat.

On May 31st there was a bombardment of the Spanish forts at the narrow entrance to the harbor of Santiago, but without result other than to locate the enemy's batteries. On June 3rd, Naval Constructor Richmond Pearson Hobson won much distinction by undertaking to sink the collier *Merrimac* in the narrow channel to prevent the escape of Cervera's fleet. The kind treatment accorded the daring Southerner by Cervera when captured, created in the United States a very favorable feeling toward Spanish officers and lessened the bitterness and contempt with which they had been regarded.

It was considered impracticable for our warships to follow Cervera's into the harbor of Santiago. Mines and batteries threatened their safety. It was resolved to take Santiago by land and thus force Cervera out. On June 10th some six hundred marines were landed at Guantanamo, some distance east of Santiago, so as to secure a place where our warships could safely take on coal from colliers. Soon after the marines were attacked by the Spanish and

six Americans were killed. There was a second attack four days later. By June 13th troops began to leave Key West for operations against Santiago, and on June 22nd General Shafter landed his army at Baiquiri, a short distance east of the entrance to the harbor of Santiago.

Several minor actions attended the advance to Juragua, Sevilla and Siboney. [A general assault was made on July 1st on the enemy's works and various commanding positions were captured. The enemy was pressed back to his inner line of fortifications. The fighting continued on the 2nd, with some loss on both sides. So difficult was the situation that at a conference of officers reported by General Breckinridge it was proposed by General Shafter to retire the army from the immediate front of Santiago until heavy artillery could be brought up to meet the fire from Cervera's fleet and from General Toral's batteries.

Admiral Cervera's dash out of the harbor on the 3rd prevented the discredit of retiring from the points already gained. The American fleet under the immediate lead of Commodore Schley, in the *Brooklyn*, met the enemy as he emerged, and in the chase that followed destroyed all the enemy's ships and took some one thousand six hundred prisoners. Admiral Sampson, in the *New York*, arrived on the scene after the action was ended.

After the Battle.

This important action logically closed the campaign, as the Spanish fleet was the sole cause of the

expedition to Santiago. But it was resolved to gather the spoils of victory, and the surrender of Santiago and the posts connected therewith were demanded by General Shafter on July 3rd, and on July 14th the city, with some twenty-four thousand troops, was surrendered by General Toral. The terms were liberal, owing to the respect inspired by the courageous defense. The Spanish were accorded the honors due to brave men, and it was stipulated in their behalf that they should be taken to Spain at the expense of the United States.

Fever Decimates the Army.

The joy and victory were dampened by the announcement on the 13th of July, that yellow fever had broken out in the army. Use of infected buildings and contact with the natives produced this regrettable result. Worse than yellow fever was the malarial fever, which decimated the regiments. A bad climate, heat, incessant rains, insanitary surroundings, deficient food and shameful lack of medical and surgical treatment produced the usual effect. The government had resolved to send the army further inland to a healthier region, but a round robin signed by a number of officers demanded the withdrawal of the army from Cuba, and this has been conceded.

Admiral Camara,

An episode of the war was Admiral Camara's voyage to the Red Sea, in June—as if on his way to the Philippines—and his return after it was an-

nounced from Washington that Commodore Watson would be sent with a fleet to harry the coast of Spain in his absence. On the way to Manila our ships from San Francisco siezed the Ladrones and other Spanish islands in the Pacific.

Porto Rico.

After the surrender of Santiago an expedition under General Miles was sent to take San Juan, Porto Rico. A landing was effected July 26th at Guanica, on the southern coast, and soon after Ponce, a town of some size, fifteen miles distant, was occupied.

Peace.

On the 26th of July, through M. Jules Cambon, the French ambassador, Spain asked what terms of peace were demanded by the United States. After some deliberation President McKinley replied demanding the evacuation of Cuba and the cession of Porto Rico and one of the Ladrones, to the United States, with certain concessions in the Philippines which will be settled by a joint commission. This is in excess of the demands with which the war began.

Navy Decided the War.

The war with Spain lasted just one hundred days, and was decided by two remarkable naval engagements, the battle at Manila and the destruction of Cervera's fleet. The attack upon Santiago, while it served to convince the Spaniards of the almost invincible character of the United States Army, was,

after all, not of a decisive character, and, had Spain still possessed a fleet, the Santiago campaign would probably have been little more than the beginning of the struggle in Cuba. But when Admiral Dewey's splendid victory at Manila was duplicated by Commodore Schley, and the flower of the Spanish navy was destroyed without appreciable damage to the American fleet, and scarcely any loss of life on board the American ships, even the Spaniards were impressed with the hopelessness of the struggle in which they were engaged.

American Losses in the War.

The losses in the Spanish-American war on the American side are as follows:—

Losses in the army: Officers killed in battle, 33; men killed in battle, 231; officers and men wounded, about 1,450; officers and men killed by disease, estimated 1,500.

Losses in navy and marine corps: Officers killed in battle, 1; men killed in battle, 13; men drowned, 1; men wounded, 38.

Lessons.

The war is supposed to have demonstrated anew the uselessness of bombardments. We have bombarded many forts without result. Torpedo boats have so far been harmless, being controlled by rapid-fire guns. Smokeless powder is shown to be preferable both for infantry and for warships. The bad marksmanship of the Spanish gunners has attracted much attention. It is partly the result of having

poor guns. In their forts this seems to have been the case but on their warships it seems to have been due to want of practice. Courage is useless unless combined with skill.